

College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

Vol. 40, No. 8

April 2026

Admissions Watch

Bowdoin Admits 6.5 Percent. Bowdoin C. in Maine attracted 14,727 applications for its Class of 2030. It offered admissions to 962 students, for an acceptance rate of 6.5 percent, the lowest in the college's history. The QuestBridge National College Match program contributed 28 students.

"Words I'd use to describe the admitted class include fearless, curious, eager, committed, bridge builders, personable, humble, kind and vulnerable," Claudia Marroquin, senior vice president and dean of admissions and student aid, told *The Bowdoin Orient*.

Brown Expands Outreach. Brown U. in Providence, Rhode Island, received 47,937 applications for its Class of 2030, 12 percent more than last year. It offered admissions to 1,674 Regular Decision applicants, 890 Early Decision applicants and 52 came through QuestBridge, for a total of 2,564 admitted students. Its acceptance rate was 5.35 percent, according to the *Brown Daily Herald*.

Applications from international students jumped by 16 percent. Apps from first-generation students rose by 15 percent and 16 percent from rural students. Students from families earning less than \$125,000 "typically pay no tuition."

Columbia Admits 4.2 Percent of Apps. Columbia C. in New York City and the university's School of Engineering and Applied Science gathered a record-breaking 61,031 applications from all 50 states and 111 countries, an increase of 1,415 applicants compared to last year. The Ivy League college admitted only 2,581 students or just 4.2 percent of applicants to its Class of 2030, according to *The Columbia Spectator*.

Last year, 1,806 students ended up enrolling, making it the largest incoming class in the university's history. This year's class is expected to be slightly smaller after intense

student, faculty and community opposition to increasing it further.

Meanwhile, Barnard C., Columbia's affiliated women's college, released its Class of 2030 decisions, but for the second consecutive year did not disclose key admissions metrics.

Cornell Admits Fewer Apps. Cornell U. in Upstate New York admitted 5,776 students to its class of 2030, almost 1 percent fewer than last year. This was the first year since 2020 that Cornell applicants were required to submit their SAT and/or ACT scores. Those admitted come from all 50 States and 102 countries and will join a community of students studying 80 majors across eight different colleges, according to *The Cornell Daily Sun*.

Denison Admits 22 Percent. Denison U. in Ohio fielded approximately 12,540 applicants for its Class of 2030 and admitted about 22 percent. Its two rounds of Early Decision attracted 1,538 applicants, with a 27 percent admission rate. Regular Decision drew 11,002 applicants and about 21 percent of them were admitted.

"The evaluative considerations used don't change across decision rounds," Meghan Huston Ulsh, vice president for enrollment management, told *The Denisonian*.

Duke Accepts 4.7 Percent of Apps. Duke received 61,935 applications for its Class of 2030, 2,000 more than the previous cycle, and admitted 2,083 prospective students through Regular Admission to join 847 Early Decision admits, for an overall acceptance rate of 4.7 percent. ED applications fell by 500, Kathy Phillips, interim dean in the undergraduate admissions office reported. Admitted students come from all 50 states and 55 nations.

Duke increased need-based financial aid from \$152 million in the 2023-24 academic year to \$171 million in the 2024-25 academic

continued on page 2

Financial Matters

Student Aid Transferred to Treasury Department. The \$1.7 trillion student aid portfolio has been transferred from the U.S. Dept. of Education to the U.S. Dept. of Treasury. Currently, fewer than 40 percent of borrowers are making repayments, according to the Dept. of Ed, and 25 percent are in default. Student aid debt is larger than cumulative credit card or auto debt combined.

"...We are undertaking the first serious effort to clean up a \$1.7 trillion portfolio that has been badly mismanaged for years," said U.S. Secretary of the Treasury Scott Bessent. "Treasury has the unique experience, the operating capability and the financial expertise to bring long overdue financial discipline to the program and be better stewards of taxpayer dollars."

FAFSA Apps Hit 10 Million. More than 10 million 2026-27 Free Application for Federal Student Aid forms have been successfully completed, according to the U.S. Dept. of Education. That represents a 17 percent increase over last year at this time and 487 percent more than two years ago, when the "improved" system faltered.

Additionally, ED said that it has updated the data powering the College Scorecard (collegescorecard.ed.gov) and the FAFSA's earnings indicator that provides students with "easy to understand information about a school's post-graduation earnings and their potential financial outcomes."

Northwestern's Medill School of Journalism Offers Loans. It's a challenging
continued on page 4

INSIDE

- Regular Decisions Arrive
- Student Loans to Treasury
- State of Counseling Profession

COLLEGE BOUND: Publisher/Editor: **R. Craig Sautter**, DePaul University; Chief Operating Officer: **Sally Reed**. Production: Design|Americom WVA.

COLLEGE BOUND is published monthly, ten times a year. See, <http://www.collegeboundnews.com>; Inquiries should be directed to P.O. Box 6536, Evanston, IL 60204; 773-262-5810.

Facebook @collegeboundnews; collegeboundnews@gmail.com; Twitter/X @cbnewsletter

ADMISSIONS WATCH

continued from page 1

year. But the cost of attendance in the 2026-27 academic year is expected to exceed \$96,000.

Lafayette Admits 32 Percent. Lafayette C. in Pennsylvania received a record-high 10,901 applications for the Class of 2030, 350 more than last year, and accepted 3,518 students for a 32.27 percent admit rate, according to *The Lafayette*. It expects 735 of these students to enroll in the fall.

"The Class of 2030 applicant pool is defined by stellar academic quality, significant expansion in our geographic reach and volume of applications," Forrest Stuart, the vice president of enrollment, told the paper.

ND Admits 9 Percent. The U. of Notre Dame in South Bend, Indiana, attracted 36,102 applications for its Class of 2030 and admitted a record-low 9 percent (for the second year in a row) from across the U.S. and 183 countries, according to *The Observer*.

"In the coming weeks, admitted students will be invited to engage with Notre Dame through a range of in-person and virtual events highlighting the university's academic, residential and spiritual life.

Pomona Admits 876. Pomona C., part of The Claremont C. consortium of five undergraduate liberal arts colleges and two graduate schools, admitted 876 students to its Class of 2030. Pomona specializes in a broad liberal arts program with strong humanities, sciences and social sciences. Its newly admitted students hail from all 50 states and 44 countries, according to Joanathan Williams, vice president and dean of admissions and financial aid.

Almost 30 percent of admitted students are the first in their family to go to college and 12 percent are international students. Twenty students from Florida and Illinois were admitted through the Posse Foundation.

Penn Attracts 61,000 Apps. The U. of Pennsylvania in Philadelphia received more than 61,000 applications for its Class of 2030, fewer than last year's 72,000. The drop in apps is attributed to the fact that the Ivy League school reinstated its standardized test requirement, which it suspended during the COVID pandemic. The QuestBridge National College Match program contributed 112 scholars.

Admitted students hail from all 50 states and 87 countries. The new cohort features the largest number of students from Philadelphia in Penn's history. "This collective breadth of experience is one of the things that makes the Penn community so dynamic, shaping student's experiences in ways they may not yet anticipate," Whitney Soule, vice provost and dean of admissions, told the *Daily*

Pennsylvanian.

Last year, 21 percent of students from Penn's admitted class were first-generation students, 24 percent were from historically underrepresented backgrounds and 57 percent identified as students of color.

Pitt Tops 72,000. The U. of Pittsburgh received more than 72,000 first-year applications for the Fall of 2026, according to *ThePittNews*. In the past seven years, applications to Pitt have surged by 120 percent, yet enrollment is up only 3 percent. A university spokesman attributed that increase to multiple applications through use of The Common Application.

Southern Cal Apps Down 5 Percent. The U. of Southern California attracted 79,290 undergraduate applications for Fall 2026, a 5 percent drop from last year's record 83,500 applications, according to the *Daily Trojan*. USC admitted 9,251 new undergraduates or about 11.2 percent of applicants. And half of the applicants in the 2026-27 admission cycle participated in the Early Action round, which constituted about 41 percent of total acceptances in this admission cycle. The acceptance rate during its Early Action round was about 9.5 percent, lower than the 11.7 percent rate last year. The average unweighted GPA of the new cohort is a record 3.92.

"The academic strength of this admitted class is truly exceptional," Timothy Brunwold, dean of admission, told the paper.

Swarthmore Admits 7.4 Percent. Swarthmore C. outside of Philadelphia attracted 13,029 applicants for its Class of 2030 and admitted 969 students for a 7.4 percent acceptance rate, according to *The Phoenix*. About 25 percent of those admitted are first in their families to go to college, the lowest percentage since 2019. Some 26 percent of those accepted came through the QuestBridge National College Match, 61 percent came through public or charter schools, 29 percent through private independent schools, the highest percentage since 2019, the paper reported.

Dean of Admissions Jim Bock told *The Phoenix* that Swarthmore experienced a decline in domestic applications and an increase in international ones, and that it admitted more international students than last year, although they come from fewer nations. Bock also said that Swarthmore does not use AI in its review process.

Tufts Admits 10 Percent. Tufts U. in Massachusetts received a record 36,000 applications for its Class of 2030. About 10 percent of admitted students are international, representing more than 60 countries.

Students in the Class of 2030 with fami-

lies earning less than \$150,000 will be the first to attend Tufts tuition-free following the announcement of the Tufts Tuition Pact last September, according to *The Tufts Daily*.

"This policy strengthens and clarifies our commitment to making Tufts affordable for admitted students," T. J. Duck said. "We meet the full demonstrated financial need of all admitted students, regardless of citizenship. Tufts is one of a relatively small number of U.S. universities that make that commitment."

About 15 percent of admitted students are also eligible for the Pell Grant, a federal grant awarded to students who demonstrate exceptional financial need.

Vanderbilt Admits 2.9 Percent of RD Apps. Vanderbilt U. in Tennessee admitted 1,382 out of its 48,720 Regular Decision applicants, the largest pool in Vanderbilt's history, to the Class of 2030. They join approximately 920 students admitted via Early Decision. RD and ED acceptance rates were 2.8 percent and 11.9 percent, respectively. Doug Christiansen, vice provost for university enrollment affairs and dean of admissions and financial aid, told *The Vanderbilt Hustler*.

Christiansen said the target for the entering class in Fall 2026 is 1,621 students, on par with past years. The increase in applicants is also in line with the steady increase in yield rate in recent years, which was 63.1 percent for the Class of 2029 and 61.2 percent for the Class of 2028. As in recent years, Christiansen expects approximately 10 percent of the class will come from the waitlist.

Williams C. Admits 7.4 Percent. Williams C. in Massachusetts received a record-breaking 15,534 Regular Decision applications for its Class of 2030, an increase of over 1,000 from last year, according to *The Williams Record*. Williams admitted 981 applicants RD. They join 258 students admitted earlier through Williams' Early Decision cycle and 14 others admitted through QuestBridge. Liz Creighton, dean of admission and financial services, told the paper.

In total, Williams admitted to 1,239 students, 74 fewer than last year. The target size of the new class is 560 students. Williams also wait listed 2,138 students and denied admission to 12,395.

Yale Received Almost 10 Percent More Apps. Yale U. in New Haven, Connecticut, attracted 54,919 applicants for its Class of 2030, an increase of 9.4 percent. The Ivy League school admitted to 2,328 scholars. Yale's cohort of admitted students includes 779 applicants who came through its Early Action cycle, plus 118 scholars who came through the QuestBridge National College Match program. ■

Spring Reports and Surveys

State of Counseling Profession. A survey of more than 6,200 practicing school counselors, conducted by the American School Counselor Association in Fall 2025, revealed 132,270 school counselors worked with 49,269,882 students. The survey said that:

- Some 54 percent of these school counselors said that high caseloads remain a significant challenge.
- 82 percent use data-informed decision-making.
- Counselors spend on average 57 percent of their time in direct student services, including 27 percent of their time in counseling, 17 percent in instruction and 13 percent in appraisals and advisements.
- Another 15 percent of their time is spent on indirect student services such as referrals, consultation and collaboration.
- “Although 66 percent of school counselors are satisfied with their role, 22 percent anticipate leaving the profession within five years, primarily due to retirement or burnout.”

Advise TN. A 2025 U. of Wisconsin–Madison study of Advise TN, Tennessee’s statewide college and career advising program, found that college advising can work on scale and that the program increased college enrollment by 3 percentage points (6 percentage points across community colleges), particularly helping Hispanic, female and rural students.

Will 40 Percent Be Denied Access to Private Student Loans? That’s the title of a new study from Protect Borrowers and The Century Foundation. It argues that the federal government’s new limits on the amount of student borrowing comes with claims that private markets likely will fill any funding gap that students may face. But this new analysis disputes that argument and maintains that as many as “40 percent of Americans, including a disproportionate amount of low-income students of color, are locked out of the traditional private student loan market” and will need to forego further education or fall prey to predatory lenders.

The study is available at <http://protectborrowers.org>.

Advisors Need Better Workforce Training Data. The National College Attainment Network surveyed organizational advisors about the frequency with which students asked them about various training programs and related issues. The bottom line?

“This survey captures a field that is genuinely interested in Workforce Pell and is already fielding student questions about short-term programs but are largely unprepared to advise on it with confidence.

“Advisors want clear information on program eligibility, quality indicators and how Workforce Pell interacts with Lifetime Eligibility and other student aid.”

Student Homelessness Update. The SchoolHouse Connection and other groups have found that nearly 14 percent of college students reported experiencing homelessness in 2024 and as many as 48 percent of students reported having difficulty maintaining stable student housing. Most of these students are not in shelters but rather stay temporarily with others. Food insecurity is also very common among these students. And 48 percent of these students screen positive for likely major depressive disorders.

Perfect, But Rejected. Why do straight “A” students or high testers get rejected? As Harvard puts it, “We do not admit by the numbers.” The February 27 issue of *Forbes* explores this idea in detail. Admissions officers are trying to put together a well-balanced class with students who have achievement and purpose.

As Aristotle put it, “The totality is not, as it were, a mere heap, but the whole is something beside the parts.” Students need to do more than heap achievement upon achievement. *Forbes* pointed out, “It is not the sheer number of items in the heap, but what the shape of it all tells the admissions committee about you.”

Admissions officers are also seeking to assemble a multi-faceted cohort.

AI’s Job Impact. According to a recent *New York Times Magazine* article, “Dario Amodei, the head of Anthropic, has warned that A.I. could eliminate 50 percent of entry-level white-collar jobs within years. The tech investor Vinod Khosla predicted last year that A.I. would replace 80 percent of jobs by 2030. Elon Musk has said the technology will render work “optional.”

“Many economists dismiss such predictions, arguing that the A.I. debate should focus less on where the economy will wind up in the end and more on the potentially difficult period of transition.”

P.S. Comings and Goings. Founded in 1958 by the Sisters of Saint Francis, **Lourdes U.** in Northern Ohio reported that it will close at the end of this school year due to financial and enrollment problems.

Meanwhile, **Gannon U.**, a Catholic school in Erie, Pennsylvania, and **Ursuline C.** in Pepper Pike, Ohio, have merged. Ursuline will operate under the name of Ursuline College Campus of Gannon University. ■

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

Richmond’s Center for Liberal Arts and AI. The U. of Richmond in Virginia opened a new cross-campus initiative to integrate AI into its students’ experience while addressing ethical and social implications. The Center for Liberal Arts and AI aims to help a student “to be a critical thinker in a liberal arts setting” and to be “creative and innovative and work with the latest tech-

nologies,” according to Lauren Tilton, the center’s director.

IU Fort Wayne Fills Health Care Jobs. Indiana U. Fort Wayne enrolls more than 1,000 students. “Each May, more than 260 graduates walk across the stage at graduation and step into the health care workforce as nurses, dental hygienists and technologists, health

scientists, radiologic imaging and sonography specialists, health administrators and social workers.” According to the *Fort Wayne Journal Gazette*, 87 percent of graduates stay for jobs in Northeastern Indiana.

Saint Martin’s U. and South Puget Sound C.C. Form a Partnership. Students from South Puget Sound C.C. in Washington can now transfer to Saint Martin’s U., a Benedictine school, in Lacey, without credit loss. ■

ENROLLMENT TRENDS

ED a “Magatrend.” Early Decision “is a megatrend,” Allan Koh, chief executive of Cardinal Education, a college consulting firm in Palo Alto, California, told the *San Francisco Chronicle*. “The game theory of college admissions has changed quite a bit” since the explosion of Early Decision. He was speaking in the wake of the U. of Southern California’s decision to launch its ED cycle this fall. “Our focus is really on enrolling students who are excited about being here at USC,” Tim Brunold, dean of admission, told the paper. He expects to fill 35 percent to 40 percent of freshmen seats through ED.

Early Decision locks students into a school that admits them regardless of its later financial aid offer. So, the trend is that more wealthy students use ED. Also, students lock themselves out of an ED application at any other school, since they can only indicate one first choice, and some schools communicate on this point.

Class Action, a non-profit organization, studied 137 universities across the country that offer Early Decision and found that in 2015, 32 percent of their freshman classes were early admits, but that number rose to 36 percent in 2024.

Does ED drive up prices for other students admitted through Regular Decision? Phillip Levine, an economics professor at Wellesley C., studied 66 schools where Early Decision admits had swelled to at least 40 percent of the entering class by 2024.

He concluded, “Colleges that expanded their

use of Early Decision did not systematically collect more revenue from freshmen.” Also, the number of Pell Grants used by low-income students, “were not correlated with changes in Early Decision use.”

Adam Nguyen, founder of Ivy Link, an admissions consulting company, told the *Chronicle of Higher Education*, “My advice to students is simple: Only apply Early Decision if it is your clear, first choice and financially viable. Otherwise, don’t do it.”

Tennessee’s Direct Admission. The Tennessee Board of Regents learned that approximately 40,000 high school students in the state’s Class of 2026 received admissions letters this spring telling them they were eligible for admission to 50 participating universities, colleges and colleges of applied technology. Students could scan the QR code on their letters and select the colleges of their choice. As of the March board meeting, 5,096 students had submitted applications to community colleges and 3,573 had submitted applications to Tennessee Colleges of Applied Technology.

Texas Post-H.S. Enrollment. Recent statistics indicate only 43 percent of Texas students go directly to college from high school compared to 61 percent nationally. That means Texas ranks 20th nationally. However, since only a third graduate from college, Texas places in the bottom 20 states for four-year college graduation rates, according to *U.S. News & World Report*. ■

NEWS YOU CAN USE

High Point Boasts that 99 Percent of Grads are Employed. High Point U. in North Carolina, whose basketball team upset Big10 giant U. of Wisconsin-Madison in the recent NCAA tournament, took advantage of that publicity to note that 99 percent of its recent graduates were either employed or furthering their education within 180 days of graduating. The school of about 6,300 students beat the national average by 14 points.

Doug Hall, vice president for career and professional development, said, “At HPU, our students gain valuable experiences and are encouraged to intentionally leverage their translatable life skills, not only for roles they know about but also for opportunities that have yet to be created.”

Indiana Latest to Use Classic Learning Test. Indiana Governor Mike Braun signed a

bill that requires the state’s higher education institutions to accept the Classic Learning Test the same way they accept the SAT or ACT. Other Republican states have done the same to promote the “Western intellectual tradition.”

Additionally, Arkansas lawmakers approved \$12 million for the classics-focused exam, as alternative to the ACT or SAT.

Also, the Indiana Senate voted 36-12 to approve Senate Bill 78, sending the measure to Governor Braun for final signoff. The legislation will require school districts and charter schools across Indiana to adopt policies prohibiting student cellphone use from the start of the school day until dismissal. Restrictions apply to common student devices including cellphones, smartwatches and gaming devices. Schools must either prohibit them entirely or require students to keep them powered off and inaccessible during the school day. ■

FINANCIAL MATTERS

continued from page 1

time for some journalism graduates looking for jobs in their field. To help some NU grads, the famed Medill School of Journalism is joining the Columbia Journalism School’s Loan Repayment Assistance Program which started this year. It is currently funded by the Knight Foundation, according to the *Daily Northwestern*.

Julie Collins, Medill’s assistant dean of graduate admissions and financial aid, told the paper that the program allows local news organizations to recruit and retain journalists while it helps students repay loans.

Tuition to Increase an Average of 3 Percent or More. *Forbes* reported that tuition is increasing across the nation to stay even with inflation. For example, in the Ivy League, Brown U. will boost its tuition by 4.25 percent, the U. of Pennsylvania by 3.9 percent. Washington State U. will increase tuition by 3.3 percent.

After freezing tuition for 11 straight years, the U. of Illinois System approved a 2 percent tuition increase for Illinois residents. Baylor U. is jumping tuition 6.5 percent. Georgetown U. is boosting it by 4.75 percent, Elon U. by 5.42 percent.

The New School located in the Greenwich Village neighborhood in New York City, announced it is increasing its 2026-27 tuition by 3.5 percent to \$31,174 for all new undergraduates. The New School provides \$1.5 million in additional financial aid to eligible Pell Grant students, according to *New School Free Press*, newschoolfreepress.com.

Meanwhile, Stanford U., the U. of Connecticut, as well as Indiana public colleges and universities, are freezing their current tuition.

Aid to Washington Private Students Cut. Students in Washington state who attend private universities and receive state financial aid will see their tuition awards reduced by nearly one third, according to yakimaherald.com.

That’s because last year the state legislature passed a bill to cut their aid to 50 percent of awards granted to students attending research institutions, such as the U. of Washington. A bill in this legislative session to reverse the cuts failed.

“By not restoring the funding, the legislature has ensured that fewer students in Washington will earn a college degree,” said Terri Standish-Kuon, CEO of the Independent Colleges of Washington. ■

To renew your subscription, go online to www.collegeboundnews.com

Annual subscription: \$59 in North America, \$69 for international orders, including airmail postage.

See, www.collegeboundnews.com

©2026 COLLEGE BOUND PUBLICATIONS, INC. All rights reserved. ISSN 1068-7912 For photocopy rights, please write the Editors.